AFTER A DISTRESSING EXPERIENCE

Children react too

Children feel a distressing experience too, even when they do not talk about it. Changes in how they behave are common afterwards. Your love and attention help them feel safe.





1 What helps

Stay close
Keep children with their family whenever possible. If you must be apart, tell them when you will be back.

Explain simply
Tell them what happened and what is happening now, in words they understand. It is all right to say “I don’t know yet”.

Give extra time
Listen, speak kindly, and give more time and affection.

Keep routines
Regular times for meals, sleep and play, even in a new place. Make new routines if the old ones are not possible.

Make time for safe play
Play, drawing and songs help children feel safer and express feelings.



2 Talking about loss

If someone has died or is missing, answer questions honestly and simply. Children may ask the same question many times. Let them share memories, through drawing or stories, if they wish.

My Hero is You, a story book for children aged 6 to 11, is available in Nepali.



3 Look after yourself too

Caring for children after a distressing experience is hard. Take a short pause when you feel angry or tired: breathe, then respond. Ask family or neighbours to share care.

- **Do not punish a child for being afraid, wetting the bed or behaving differently.**
- **Do not leave children alone with people you do not know.**

When to ask for help

Talk to a health worker if changes in your child go on for a long time or get worse, if your child stops eating, playing or talking, or if your child talks about hurting themselves. If a child is alone, separated from their family, or at risk of harm, tell a responder or _____ (child protection contact, filled in locally) straight away.

What you may notice



Young children
Clinging, crying more, wetting the bed again, trouble sleeping, or being afraid when you are out of sight



Older children
Being very quiet or very restless, getting angry easily, trouble concentrating, or playing out what happened again and again



Adolescents
Staying away from others, being irritable, worrying about the family, or taking risks

Children with disabilities

Children with disabilities may need more time, clear routines and your help to join play. For more, see the leaflet for parents of children and adolescents with disabilities (CMC-Nepal).

Ask for help early

Changes in your child getting worse, not going away, or making daily life hard? Talk to a health worker. You do not have to wait.

Get help now

In danger, or thinking of harming yourself? Get help now. Ask a health worker or responder, and ask someone you trust to stay with you.

Help near you: _____ (filled in and checked locally)

_____

_____

Look after yourself. Look after each other.

Support is for everyone, including people with disabilities and older people. Ask for large print or more time.

Sources: WHO and UNICEF, Helping children cope with stress (2020); WHO, UNICEF and partners, Parenting for Lifelong Health tips (2020); IASC, My Hero is You (2020); WHO, Psychological First Aid: Guide for Field Workers (2011); WHO/UNHCR, mhGAP Humanitarian Intervention Guide (2015). This material draws on these publications; it was not created by WHO, UNICEF or IASC, which are not responsible for its content.

Take-home leaflet · A4 · Chapter 4 of 6 · English review draft · Not for field distribution. Fictional illustrations, AI-assisted and developed under human direction.